

Here Comes a Bluebird

♩ ~ 118

Form: A(aa)B(bc)

Text and Singing Game: William Wells Newell (1884)

Melody: Florence Warren Brown & Neva L. Boyd (1915)

Song Type: Singing Game

Form Type: Strophic

Toneset: **drm** sl

Scale Type: do-pentatonic

Handwritten musical notation for the song "Here Comes a Bluebird". The notation is written on four staves. The first staff has a "4" in the margin. The notes are labeled with letters: s, l, s, m, s, l, s, m. The lyrics are: "Here comes a blue bird through the win- dow". The second staff has a "4" in the margin. The notes are labeled with letters: m, r, r, r, r, d, m, d. The lyrics are: "hi — did- dle- dum- a- day, day, day". The third staff has a "4" in the margin. The notes are labeled with letters: s, s, s, l, s, m, s, l, s, m. The lyrics are: "Take a lit- tle part- ner, hop in the gar- den,". The fourth staff has a "4" in the margin. The notes are labeled with letters: m, r, r, r, r, d, m, d. The lyrics are: "hi — did- dle- dum- a- day, day, day."

Formation: Standing circle with hands joined and raised, palm facing palm. One person, the Bluebird is on the inside or outside; it doesn't matter as long as they– the Bluebird– are separate from the circle.

Bluebird walks/flies in and out under the arches.

On "Take a little partner," Bluebird faces a partner, and takes hands. They hop three or four times on one foot during "hop in the garden" to change places. This can be easily modified for various abilities and comfort levels, but I model it as such.

The partner becomes the new Bluebird, and the game is repeated.

Source: Brown, F.W. & Boyd, N. L. (1915). *Old English and American games for school and playground* (p. 47). H.T. FitzSimons Company.

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What stands out to me pedagogically:

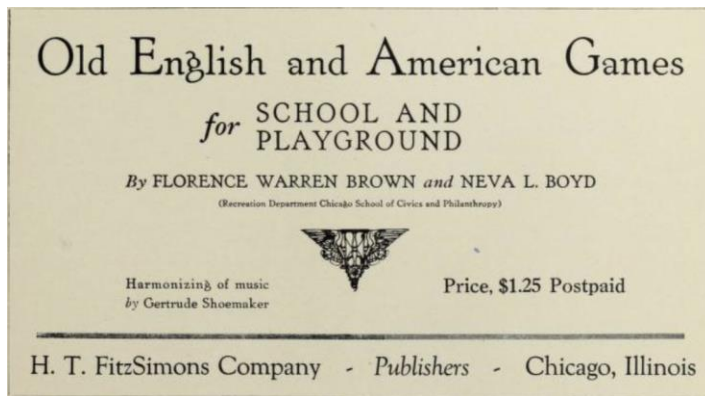
Rhythm: This song is excellent for hearing one sound that lasts for two beats and may eventually be called a half note.

Melody: A staple for pentatonic that can lead to identification, part-work, or any other aural skills or written notation practice.

Other: "Here comes a bluebird through the window." This is an excellent opportunity to hear one sound that changes notes and may later be called a slur. Slurs are melodic concepts, where two sounds happen during one note.

Contextual Information

The perennial favorite *Bluebird* is documented in the American Folksong Collection, fka Holy Names ([link](#)). Their source is a book called *Old English and American Games for School and Playground*, which documents the melody, text and singing game. The authors describe this as a singing game that likely originated in the U.S. and cite Newell, included on the next page.



HERE COMES A BLUE BIRD.

1. { Here comes a blue - bird through the win - dow, Hi - did - dle - dum - a - day, day, day. }
{ Take a lit - tle part - ner, hop in the gar - den, Hi - did - dle - dum - a - day, day, day. }

The children stand, with hands joined, in a ring. One child walks in and out under the arches. On "Take a little partner," this child takes a partner, and with both hands joined they face each other and gallop out through the opening where the child was taken from the ring, and back again, or dance the same around inside the ring. The first child joins the ring, the partner becomes the bluebird, and the game is repeated.

NOTE.—Newell says the color of the bird is determined by the color of the child's dress and the song is changed to "Here comes a red bird," etc., but it is popularly sung "blue bird," without regard to the child's dress.
This game probably originated in America.

HERE COMES A BLUE BIRD.

1. { Here comes a blue - bird through the win - dow, through the win - dow, through the win - dow, My fair la - dy.
{ Here comes a blue - bird through the win - dow, My fair la - dy. }

2. Take a little partner and hop in the garden, hop in the garden.
Take a little partner and hop in the garden, my fair lady.

This is played in exactly the same way as the foregoing.

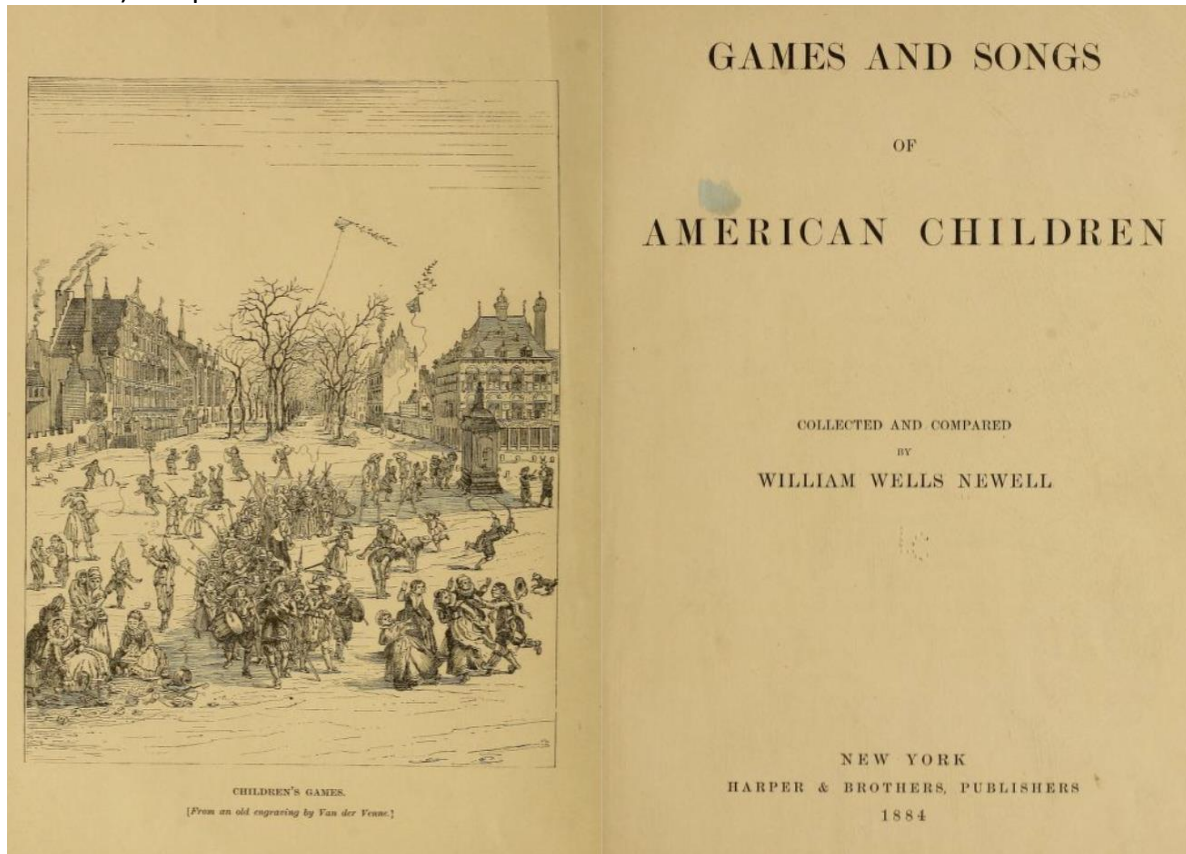
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William Wells Newell documented the text and singing game in an 1884 publication, noting that it was from Cincinnati. The introduction to this text is worth reading, and the whole book is available on archive.org ([link](#)).

Newell, W. W. (1884). *Games and songs of American children: Collected and compared* (pp. 118–119). Harper & Brothers Publishers.



No. 51.
Blue-birds and Yellow-birds.
A ring of girls with their hands clasped and lifted. A girl, called (according to the color of her dress) blue-bird, black-bird, yellow-bird, etc., enters, and passes into the ring under an arch formed by a pair of lifted hands, singing to any suitable tune:
Here comes a blue-bird through the window,
Here comes a blue-bird through the window,
Here comes a blue-bird through the window,
High diddle dum day!

Bird and Beast. 119
She seizes a child, and waltzes off with her, singing:
Take a little dance and a hop-i'-the-corner,*
Take a little dance and a hop-i'-the-corner,
Take a little dance and a hop-i'-the-corner,
High diddle dum day!
After the dance the chosen partner leads, named, as before, according to the color of her costume. The child, as she enters, must imitate by her raised arms the flight of a bird, making a very pretty dance.
Cincinnati.